

Home & Housework

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NOUNS

chore

a routine household task

The children were each given a list of daily chores.

dust

fine dry particles of dirt that settle on surfaces

There was a thick layer of dust on the bookshelves.

washing

clothes and linen that need to be washed

There's a pile of washing that needs to be done.

clutter

an untidy accumulation of objects not in order

She spent the weekend clearing the clutter from the spare room.

renovation

the process of improving or restoring a building or room

They moved out while the renovation was being carried out.

mould

a fungal growth that appears on damp surfaces

There was mould forming in the corners of the bathroom ceiling.

grime

thick dirt that has built up over time on a surface

Years of grime had built up on the kitchen ceiling.

mess

an untidy or dirty state

The kitchen was in a complete mess after the party.

rubbish

waste material to be thrown away (British English)

Can you take the rubbish out before the lorry comes?

hoovering

the act of vacuuming floors and carpets

I usually do the hoovering on Sunday mornings.

maintenance

the work of keeping something in good condition

Regular maintenance of the boiler will prevent costly breakdowns.

limescale

a hard white deposit that builds up from hard water

There was thick limescale around the taps and showerhead.

disrepair

a poor condition caused by neglect and lack of maintenance

The property had fallen into disrepair after years of neglect.

a slob

a person who is habitually lazy, untidy, or lacking in personal hygiene

He's a complete slob. There are dirty plates everywhere.

ADJECTIVES

tidy

arranged neatly and in order

He always keeps his desk tidy, even during busy periods.

messy

untidy and dirty

The bathroom was absolutely messy after the kids' bath time.

spotless

perfectly clean; free of any marks or dirt

She left the kitchen spotless after the dinner party.

immaculate

perfectly clean and tidy; free from any blemish

The flat was immaculate. You'd never guess anyone lived there.

run-down

(of a building or area) in poor condition from lack of care

The house was completely run-down when they bought it.

squalid

extremely dirty and unpleasant, often through neglect

The students had left the house in a squalid state.

cluttered

untidy and full of objects that are not well organised

The garage was too cluttered to fit a car in.

meticulous

giving very careful attention to every detail

She was meticulous about cleaning. Every corner was inspected.

pristine

in its original clean condition; unspoiled

Despite being fifty years old, the kitchen was in pristine condition.

VERBS

clean

to make something free from dirt or mess

She spent the morning cleaning the bathroom from top to bottom.

sweep

to clean a floor by pushing dirt away with a brush

She swept the kitchen floor after dinner.

scrub

to clean something thoroughly by rubbing it hard

She scrubbed the tiles until they were white again.

refurbish

to renovate and redecorate a building or room

The landlord agreed to refurbish the kitchen before new tenants arrived.

vacuum

to clean a floor or carpet using a vacuum cleaner

He vacuums the living room every Saturday morning.

iron

to press clothes with a heated iron to remove creases

She irons her shirts the night before work.

declutter

to remove unnecessary items from a space to make it tidier

They spent the bank holiday decluttering the loft.

PHRASAL VERBS

tidy up

to make a place neat by putting things in their proper place

Can you tidy up the living room before the guests arrive?

clear up

to tidy or clean a place after an activity

It took us two hours to clear up after the party.

throw out

to dispose of something you no longer need

She threw out a whole bin bag of old clothes.

put away

to return items to their correct storage place

If everyone put things away after using them, the house would stay tidy.

nod off

to fall asleep, especially without meaning to
I always nod off on the sofa halfway through a film.

lying around

existing or present in a place without being used or put away
There are old magazines lying around the living room.

clear out

to remove all unwanted items from a space
We need to clear out the garage before winter.

do up

to renovate or redecorate a property
They bought an old cottage and spent two years doing it up.

put off

to delay doing something you don't want to do
I keep putting off cleaning the oven because it's such a horrible job.

wipe down

to clean a surface by rubbing it with a cloth
She wiped down the counters after cooking.

build up

to accumulate gradually on a surface
Grease tends to build up around the hob if it isn't cleaned regularly.

COLLOCATIONS

make the bed

to straighten the bedcovers and pillows after sleeping
She always makes the bed before leaving the house.

natural light

daylight that enters a room through windows, rather than from lamps or bulbs
The flat faces south, so the living room gets loads of natural light.

home comforts

the familiar, everyday pleasures of your own house, such as good food or a soft bed
After a month of travelling, I was craving home comforts: my own shower, my own pillow.

do the laundry

to wash a load of clothes
He does the laundry every Sunday without fail.

keep on top of

to manage something regularly so it doesn't get out of control
It's much easier to keep on top of the housework little and often.

from top to bottom

completely and thoroughly, from one end to the other
She cleaned the flat from top to bottom before the move.

IDIOMS

in a state

in a very untidy or disordered condition
The kitchen was in a complete state after the party.

not lift a finger

to do nothing to help with household tasks
He sat watching TV and didn't lift a finger while she cleaned.

elbow grease

hard physical effort, especially when cleaning or polishing
The stove was filthy. It took real elbow grease to get it clean.

creature of habit

a person who always does things the same way and dislikes change to their routine
I'm such a creature of habit: same breakfast, same seat on the train, every single day.

spick and span

perfectly clean and tidy

She had the flat spick and span before the landlord's inspection.

a lick of paint

a small amount of painting done to freshen up a room

The hallway just needs a lick of paint and it'll look brand new.

SET PHRASES

make yourself at home

said to a guest, inviting them to relax and behave as if they were in their own house

Grab a drink from the fridge and make yourself at home. I won't be a minute.

MODERN SLANG

blitz

to clean or tidy a place quickly and intensively

We blitzed the flat before the viewing.

pad

a person's home or flat

Come round and check out my new pad. I've only just finished unpacking.